

The Four Marian Dogmas

What the Church Has Defined about Mary

A source-audited doctrinal reference

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1 Four Dogmas, One Economy

The Catholic Church counts four truths about the Blessed Virgin Mary among its dogmas: that she is truly Mother of God (*Theotokos*); that she is ever-virgin—before, in, and after the birth of her Son; that she was conceived immaculate, preserved from all stain of original sin from the first instant of her conception; and that, her earthly life completed, she was assumed body and soul into heavenly glory. This reference states, for each of the four, exactly what was defined, by whom, with what authority, and from what scriptural and traditional roots; what the definition does not assert; and how the Church presently teaches it.

A dogma, in the Church’s strict usage, is a truth contained in the word of God, written or handed down, which the Church proposes as divinely revealed—whether by a solemn judgment or by her ordinary and universal magisterium—and which therefore calls for the assent of divine and Catholic faith. The First Vatican Council fixed that criterion in its constitution *Dei Filius* (1870).¹ Not every true or authoritative statement about Mary is a dogma: the four treated here are the ones commonly so identified because each meets that strict standard. Their modes of proposal differ, and the differences matter.

Governing thesis

The four Marian dogmas confess one work of God, not four privileges of Mary considered alone. Because the eternal Son truly became man from her, she is Mother of God; because her whole self was given to that motherhood, she is ever-virgin; because the Redeemer’s merits reached her first and most perfectly, she was preserved from original sin; because her body shared the Redeemer’s victory, she was assumed into glory. Each dogma was defined in a different mode—two in the ancient conciliar and traditional inheritance, two by solemn papal definition—and each leaves identified questions deliberately open. Everything defined is received: nothing in the four makes Mary a source of grace independent of Christ, the sole Redeemer and Mediator.

The two ancient dogmas were fixed in the Christological crisis of the fifth to seventh centuries: the divine motherhood at the Council of Ephesus (431) and in the councils that received it, the perpetual virginity through the Church’s universal tradition, confessed in creeds and councils and given an exact threefold formulation by the Lateran Council of 649. The two modern dogmas were defined *ex cathedra* by Pius IX in *Ineffabilis Deus* (1854) and Pius XII in *Munificentissimus Deus* (1950)—the two acts universally cited as exercises of the papal teaching authority that the First Vatican Council would define in 1870. Denial of a dogma is not mere disagreement with a theological school; both modern definitions attach a formal sanction to willful denial, quoted below with their texts.

Method, throughout: the exact defined text is quoted from an identified witness and set off typographically; the doctrinal history is traced to the definition, not read backwards from it; scriptural and patristic evidence is weighted honestly, with translation cares stated; and the boundary between dogma, authoritative teaching, and theological opinion is kept explicit, above all for the disputed cooperation titles treated in the final chapter. Work-wide bounds, terminology, and qualifications are gathered in the terminal appendix.

2 Mother of God: the Divine Motherhood

The defined object and its authority

The dogma: Mary is truly Mother of God, because the Son she conceived and bore according to the flesh is the eternal Word of God in person. The controlling act is the Council of Ephesus (431), which did not issue a new creed but judged Cyril of Alexandria’s second letter to Nestorius to be the faith of Nicaea. The conciliar acts record that after the letters of Cyril to Nestorius were read, “the Holy Synod approved” them “as being orthodox and without fault,” in no point disagreeing with Scripture or with the faith of Nicaea.² The letter’s decisive sentence, in the same public-domain translation:

Defined text — Cyril’s second letter to Nestorius, approved at Ephesus, 431 (DS 251)

“This was the sentiment of the holy Fathers; therefore they ventured to call the Holy Virgin, the Mother of God, not as if the nature of the Word or his divinity had its beginning from the Holy Virgin, but because of her was

born that holy body with a rational soul, to which the Word being personally united is said to be born according to the flesh.”³

The Council of Chalcedon (451) made the title part of its Definition of Faith—the Son is “born [into the world] of the Virgin Mary, the Mother of God according to his manhood”—and the Second Council of Constantinople (553) anathematized whoever calls her Mother of God only “in a false acception” or “in a relative sense.”⁴ The dogma is thus conciliar, defined within Christology: what was at stake at Ephesus was not a privilege of Mary but the unity of Christ.

Scripture, honestly weighted

Scripture never uses the word *Theotokos*; it supplies the reality the word protects. Elizabeth greets Mary as “the mother of my Lord” (Lk 1:43); Paul writes that “God sent his Son, made of a woman” (Gal 4:4); John, that “the Word was made flesh” (Jn 1:14).⁵ The inference is short and ancient: if the one born of Mary is God the Son, then Mary is the mother of God the Son—mother of a person, not manufacturer of a nature. Motherhood terminates in the person born, and the person born of Mary is the eternal Word.

History to the definition

The title was in devotional and episcopal use well before 431; the controversy began in 428 when Nestorius, newly bishop of Constantinople, supported preaching that rejected *Theotokos* in favor of *Christotokos*, “Mother of Christ,” fearing the word made Mary a goddess or the Godhead newborn. Cyril’s letters answered that the objection dissolved once the unity of Christ was held: the Word was not changed into flesh, nor joined to a separate man, but “personally united” himself to flesh animated by a rational soul.⁶ Theodosius II convoked the council at Ephesus; the Formula of Union (433) between Cyril and the Antiochenes confessed the title again; Chalcedon and Constantinople II fixed it in conciliar definition. From the fifth century the title never again left the Church’s liturgy or creeds.

What the dogma does and does not assert

It asserts: the child of Mary is God the Son in person; his conception and birth from her are truly the conception and birth, according to the flesh, of the Word. It does not assert: that Mary is the origin of the divine nature; that she existed before God or is mother of the Trinity; that anything divine “began” in her. The common misunderstanding runs in both directions—Nestorius’s fear that the title deifies Mary, and the converse modern reading that “Mother of God” claims too much for her. Both dissolve on the same distinction: mothers bear persons, not natures. The Catechism gives the current catechetical form: the one Mary conceived “was none other than the Father’s eternal Son” and the Church confesses her as truly Mother of God (CCC 495, citing DS 251; cf. CCC 484–487).⁷ *Lumen gentium* opens its Marian chapter from the same point: Mary is honored “as being truly the Mother of God and of the redeemer” (LG 53, quoted at CCC 963).⁸ The divine motherhood is the ground of every other Marian dogma: the remaining three state what God’s grace made of the woman whose Son is God.

3 Ever-Virgin: the Perpetual Virginity

The defined object and its authority

The dogma: Mary was and remained a virgin—in conceiving her Son (*ante partum*), in giving him birth (*in partu*), and ever after (*post partum*); she is *aeiparthenos*, “ever-virgin.” Unlike the other three dogmas, this one rests on no single defining act. It is ancient dogma taught by the Church’s universal tradition, confessed in the creeds (“born of the Virgin Mary”), asserted by the Second Council of Constantinople (553), which twice calls Mary Mother of God “and always a virgin” in its anathemas (DS 427), and given its most exact conciliar formulation by the Lateran Council of 649 under Pope Martin I—not an ecumenical council, but a papally confirmed synod whose third canon the Church has received as a standard statement of the dogma.⁹

Defined text — Lateran Council of 649, canon 3 (DS 503), Latin
“Si quis secundum sanctos Patres non confitetur proprie et secundum veritatem Dei genitricem sanctam semperque Virginem et immaculatam Mariam, utpote ipsum Deum Verbum specialiter et veraciter, qui a Deo Patre ante omnia saecula natus est, in ultimis saeculorum absque semine concepisse ex Spiritu Sancto, et incorruptibiliter eum genuisse, indissolubili permanente et post partum eiusdem virginitate, condemnatus sit.” ¹⁰

The canon binds together all three moments: conception without seed by the Holy Spirit; incorrupt birth; virginity indissolubly permanent after birth. Note the canon’s own word *immaculatam*—an early witness to the language, though not to the 1854 definition’s object.

Scripture, honestly weighted

Scripture directly teaches the virginal conception: Matthew 1:18–25 and Luke 1:26–35 assert it in narrative and Mary’s own question—“How shall this be done, because I know not man?” (Lk 1:34)—presupposes it.¹¹ The full threefold confession is received through Tradition; Scripture neither states nor denies virginity in and after birth. The standing objections are old and must be answered at their own linguistic scale, not with knock-down certainty: the “brothers and sisters” of Jesus (Mk 6:3 etc.) use kinship terms whose range in the Semitic background is wider than sibling, and the Church has always understood these passages as not referring to other children of Mary—the Catechism notes that James and Joseph, “brothers of Jesus,” are elsewhere the sons of another Mary (CCC 500); Matthew’s “till she brought forth her firstborn son” (Mt 1:25) asserts what was true up to the birth without asserting a change after it, a normal Semitic usage; “firstborn” is a legal status of the child that opens the womb, not a count of siblings.¹²

History to the formulation

The virginal conception is confessed from the earliest creeds and by Ignatius of Antioch (CCC 496–497). The second-century *Protevangelium of James* already narrates Mary’s virginity preserved in birth—apocryphal, worthless as biography, but weighty as evidence of what second-century Christians believed. The fourth century tested the doctrine in controversy: against Helvidius, who read the “brothers” as later children, Jerome wrote *On the Perpetual Virginity of Blessed Mary* (383), defending the tradition and proposing the cousins reading received in the West; the East preferred the tradition of Joseph’s sons by a prior marriage. Both readings preserve the dogma; neither is defined.¹³ From the fifth century, *aeiparthenos* is standard; Constantinople II and Lateran 649 fix it in conciliar language, and the ordinary universal magisterium has taught it continuously since.

What the dogma does and does not assert

It asserts a real, bodily, lifelong virginity, integral in the act of birth itself: the Second Vatican Council repeats the tradition that Christ’s birth “did not diminish His mother’s virginal integrity but sanctified it” (LG 57), and the Church celebrates Mary as *Aeiparthenos* (CCC 499).¹⁴ It does not assert any anatomical or obstetric theory: the Church has never defined the physiology of the birth, and the dogma is not a medical claim. It does not assert that marriage or childbirth is impure—the tradition reads Mary’s virginity as the sign of her undivided gift of self and of God’s absolute initiative in the Incarnation (CCC 503–506), not as a judgment on ordinary motherhood. And it does not depend on contempt for the “brothers of the Lord,” who remain real kinsmen of Jesus in the Church’s reading. The common misunderstanding—that the dogma stands or falls with a single proof-text—mistakes its mode: it is Tradition’s dogma, formulated conciliarly, in which Scripture is read within the Church’s rule of faith.

4 Conceived Without Sin: the Immaculate Conception

The defined text and its authority

On 8 December 1854, in the apostolic constitution *Ineffabilis Deus*, Pius IX defined:

Defined text — *Ineffabilis Deus*, Pius IX, 8 December 1854 (DS 2803)

“We declare, pronounce, and define that the doctrine which holds that the most Blessed Virgin Mary, in the first instance of her conception, by a singular grace and privilege granted by Almighty God, in view of the merits of Jesus Christ, the Savior of the human race, was preserved free from all stain of original sin, is a doctrine revealed by God and therefore to be believed firmly and constantly by all the faithful.”¹⁵

The constitution continues with a formal sanction: whoever “shall dare—which God forbid!—to think otherwise than as has been defined by us” has “suffered shipwreck in the faith” and separated from the Church’s unity (DS 2804).¹⁶ The level is the highest: a solemn papal definition of divinely revealed doctrine, binding the whole Church.

Reading the definition’s clauses

Every phrase is load-bearing. “In the first instance of her conception”: the grace touches Mary’s origin itself, not a later cleansing. “Singular grace and privilege”: unique to her; the definition creates no general class. “In view of the merits of Jesus Christ” (*intuitu meritorum*): the decisive clause—Mary is not exempt from redemption but is its most perfect case, redeemed by anticipation, preserved rather than rescued. “Preserved free from all stain of original sin”: the object is original sin only; Mary’s lifelong freedom from personal sin is a closely related but distinct teaching, not the thing defined here (CCC 493).¹⁷

Scripture, honestly weighted

The definition names no proof-text in its defining sentence; the constitution’s own survey reads two loci within Tradition. Genesis 3:15, the enmity God sets “between thee and the woman, and thy seed and her seed,” is read by the Fathers and the constitution as foretelling the Redeemer and prophetically indicating his Mother, joined without compromise to the serpent’s defeat. Translation care is required: the Vulgate reads *ipsa conteret*, “she shall crush,” where the Hebrew subject is the seed (“he/it”); the doctrinal argument rests on the enmity, not on the disputed pronoun.¹⁸ Luke 1:28, Gabriel’s greeting, transliterated *kecharitomene*, is a perfect passive participle of *charitoo*, “to grace, to favor”: the greeting names Mary as one already graced. The Vulgate renders *gratia plena* and the Douay-Rheims “full of grace”; many modern versions render “favored one.” The word alone does not state the 1854 dogma; the Church reads it cumulatively, as the Catechism does (CCC 490–491), within the tradition of Mary’s singular holiness.¹⁹

History to the definition: from difficulty to resolution

The patristic centuries supply a matrix, not the formula: the New Eve parallel from Justin and Irenaeus onward, the East’s praise of Mary as all-holy (*Panagia*), the language of Lateran 649 (*immaculatam*), the Eastern feast of Mary’s conception. No pre-Nicene Father states the first-instant formula, and Augustine’s famous exemption of Mary—“out of honor to the Lord” he would raise no question of sin about her—concerns personal sin, not the conception (CCC 491–493 reads the development as the Church becoming “ever more aware” of what grace had done).²⁰ The medieval schools then produced the classic difficulty: how could Mary be sinless from conception and still be redeemed by Christ, Savior of all? Bernard of Clairvaux objected to the new conception feast; Thomas Aquinas, holding that Mary was sanctified in the womb before birth, denied sanctification prior to animation precisely to protect universal redemption: otherwise “she would not have needed redemption and salvation which is by Christ.”²¹ John Duns Scotus supplied the resolution received into the definition: preservation is the more perfect mode of redemption—Christ, the most perfect Mediator, could preserve his Mother from contracting original sin, and preserving grace is a greater debt to his merits than liberating grace (*Ordinatio* III, d. 3, q. 1). The tag *potuit, deuit, fecit* summarizes the argument but is a later schoolroom formula, not a checked verbatim quotation of Scotus.²² The papacy then steered the question for four centuries: Sixtus IV approved the feast (*Cum praeexcelsa*, 1476) and forbade either side to censure the other (*Grave nimis*, 1483); Trent declared it was “not its intention” to include Mary in its decree on original sin (1546; DS 1516); Alexander VII fixed the object of the feast as the soul’s preservation “in the first instant of its creation” and infusion (*Sollicitudo omnium ecclesiarum*, 1661); Pius IX consulted the episcopate (1849) and defined (1854).²³

What the dogma does and does not assert

It asserts Mary's preservation from original sin from the first instant, by grace, through Christ's merits. It does not assert that Mary needed no redeemer—it asserts the opposite, in terms. It does not concern the virginal conception of Jesus, with which it is perennially confused: the Immaculate Conception is Mary's own conception by her parents in the ordinary way, immaculate in grace, not in manner. It does not define Mary's freedom from concupiscence's effects in detail, her exemption from bodily death, or any physiological claim. And it does not make the medieval doctors' hesitation retroactively heretical: the Church defined after the development, and the honest record of Bernard's and Thomas's difficulty is part of the dogma's history, preserved in this reference as the profile requires. Current catechesis: CCC 490–493, 508; LG 56, 59.

5 Assumed into Glory: the Assumption

The defined text and its authority

On 1 November 1950, in the apostolic constitution *Munificentissimus Deus*, Pius XII defined:

Defined text — *Munificentissimus Deus*, Pius XII, 1 November 1950, §44 (DS 3903)

“... by the authority of our Lord Jesus Christ, of the Blessed Apostles Peter and Paul, and by our own authority, we pronounce, declare, and define it to be a divinely revealed dogma: that the Immaculate Mother of God, the ever Virgin Mary, having completed the course of her earthly life, was assumed body and soul into heavenly glory.”²⁴

The sanction follows immediately: anyone who “should dare willfully to deny or to call into doubt that which we have defined” has “fallen away completely from the divine and Catholic Faith” (§45; DS 3904).²⁵ This is the one exercise of the solemn *ex cathedra* mode after its 1870 definition, and the constitution grounds it in a formal consultation of the whole episcopate: the 1946 letter *Deiparae Virginis Mariae* asked the bishops whether the bodily Assumption “can be proposed and defined as a dogma of faith,” and their response, with clergy and faithful, was “almost unanimous”—an agreement the Pope reads as itself a proof, since the ordinary teaching of the united episcopate is infallible (§§11–12). The definition also names its own title to the deposit: a truth “based on the Sacred Writings, ... thoroughly rooted in the minds of the faithful, ... approved in ecclesiastical worship from the most remote times” (§41).²⁶

What was deliberately left open

The definition says “having completed the course of her earthly life” (*expleto terrestres vitae cursu*)—and stops. It does not define whether Mary died. The constitution freely reports the tradition of her death: the liturgical books treat “the dormition or the Assumption,” and John Damascene, its chief witness, preaches that her “sacred body” did not see corruption after death (§§17–21). But the defining sentence was drawn so as to leave the death–dormition question open, and theologians on both sides have since argued it legitimately. The dogma likewise does not state where or when the Assumption occurred, does not canonize any *Transitus* narrative, and does not assert that Mary's glorification bypassed the common human end—only that, however her earthly course was completed, she was taken up body and soul.²⁷

Scripture, honestly weighted

There is no Assumption narrative in the New Testament, and the constitution claims none. Its stated position is that the proofs of the Fathers and theologians are “based upon the Sacred Writings as their ultimate foundation”: Scripture sets the Mother inseparably beside her Son and his lot (§38); from the second century she is the new Eve, associated with the new Adam in the struggle foretold in the proteo-evangelium (Gen 3:15), a struggle ending in victory over sin and death, as Paul's resurrection texts announce (§39; cf. 1 Cor 15:54–57). Psalm 132, Revelation 12, and the other loci the tradition uses appear in the constitution as the theologians' figures, reported as such (§§26–27). The scriptural case is thus a canonical and Christological horizon within which Tradition's testimony is read—not a chain of narrative proof-texts, and the constitution is candid about that structure.²⁸

History to the definition

The historical argument of the constitution runs through worship and teaching rather than through early narrative: the feast of the Dormition in the East, adopted at Rome by the eighth century and elevated thereafter; the homilies of the great eighth-century preachers, above all John Damascene—“It was fitting that she, who had kept her virginity intact in childbirth, should keep her own body free from all corruption even after death” (§21); the scholastic reception from Amadeus of Lausanne through Anthony of Padua, Albert, Thomas, Bonaventure, and Bernardine of Siena; the modern theology manuals; and the swelling petitions of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries after 1854. On Thomas the constitution is exact and modest: he “never dealt directly with this question,” yet whenever he touched it held with the Church that Mary’s body was assumed with her soul (§31)—general principles and occasional affirmations, not a dedicated proof, and this reference claims no more.²⁹

What the dogma does and does not assert

It asserts that Mary, body and soul, already shares the glory of her Son’s Resurrection. It does not assert an ascension: Christ ascended by his own power; Mary was *assumed*, taken up by God’s act—the passive is doctrinal. It is not an apotheosis: she remains a creature, glorified wholly by grace. It does not add a fifth article about her death, her final illness, or a tomb. Its doctrinal fruit is eschatological and ecclesial: the Assumption is “a singular participation in her Son’s Resurrection” and an anticipation of the resurrection promised to all members of his Body (CCC 966, quoting LG 59; CCC 974); in Mary the Church contemplates what she herself will be (CCC 972).³⁰

6 The Boundary of the Defined: Titles, Doctrines, Opinions

Authoritative teaching that is not a fifth dogma

Several firm Marian teachings stand near the four dogmas without being among them, and a reference must keep the categories visible. Mary’s freedom from personal sin throughout her life is constant authoritative teaching (CCC 493: “By the grace of God Mary remained free of every personal sin her whole life long”) but is not the object of the 1854 definition. Her spiritual motherhood of the faithful and the title Mother of the Church (proclaimed by Paul VI in 1964, echoed at CCC 963, 975) are authoritative teaching. Her Queenship is taught by the Assumption definition’s own horizon and by LG 59 (“exalted by the Lord as Queen of the universe”), yet no separate coronation dogma exists. Each of these binds in its own mode; none carries the four dogmas’ definitional form.³¹

Cooperation, mediation, and the disputed titles

Mary’s cooperation in the work of salvation is real and conciliar doctrine: she “cooperated by her obedience, faith, hope, and burning charity in the Savior’s work,” and is “a mother to us in the order of grace” (LG 61, quoted at CCC 968). But the Council fenced the language on every side. There is “but one Mediator” (1 Tim 2:5; LG 60), and Mary’s maternal role “in no wise obscures or diminishes this unique mediation of Christ, but rather shows His power”; her influence “flows forth from the superabundance of the merits of Christ, rests on His mediation, depends entirely on it and draws all its power from it” (LG 60). The Church does invoke her “under the titles of Advocate, Auxiliatrix, Adjutrix, and Mediatrix,” yet “this, however, is to be so understood that it neither takes away from nor adds anything to the dignity and efficaciousness of Christ the one Mediator” (LG 62).³²

The proposal to define a fifth Marian dogma—Mary as Co-redemptrix, Mediatrix of All Graces, and Advocate—has circulated in petition movements since the twentieth century. It stands *outside* the four dogmas, and the Holy See has now judged its central title directly. The Dicastery for the Doctrine of the Faith’s doctrinal note *Mater Populi Fidelis*, approved by Pope Leo XIV on 7 October 2025 and published 4 November 2025, concludes that “it is always inappropriate to use the title ‘Co-redemptrix’ to define Mary’s cooperation,” because the title “risks obscuring Christ’s unique salvific mediation” (§22). On mediation it teaches that the Council deliberately preferred the language of cooperation and maternal assistance (§27); on “Mediatrix of All Graces” it observes that Mary, “the first redeemed, could not have been the mediatrix of the grace that she herself received” (§67), while allowing that her intercession may implore the “actual graces” that prepare and accompany conversion (§69).³³ *Advocate*, retained by LG 62, means

Mary’s maternal intercession within Christ’s mediation—never protection from a merciless Father or a reluctant Christ.

The doctrinal test that governs every Marian title follows from the four dogmas themselves: whatever is said of Mary must be received, created, participated, and wholly dependent on the one Redeemer. Said that way, the titles guard the dogmas; said otherwise, they obscure them. That is the boundary this reference draws, and it is the Church’s own.

7 Synopses of the Four Dogmas

Each synopsis condenses the corresponding chapter without erasing its historical difficulty; the chapter and its notes control.

Synopsis — Divine Motherhood (*Theotokos*)

Object: Mary is truly Mother of God: the Son born of her according to the flesh is the eternal Word in person.

Mode and authority: Conciliar dogma within Christology: Ephesus (431) approving Cyril’s second letter to Nestorius (DS 250–251); Chalcedon (451) Definition of Faith; Constantinople II (553) anathemas.

Biblical center: Lk 1:43 (“mother of my Lord”); Gal 4:4; Jn 1:14. Scripture supplies the reality, not the word.

Principal early witnesses: Pre-431 devotional and episcopal use of *Theotokos*; Cyril’s letters; conciliar reception 431–553.

Thomistic support or limit: Fully affirmed; classic locus ST III, q. 35 (motherhood terminates in the person), consistent with the account given here, cited at that generality.

Development hinge: Nestorius’s *Christotokos* (428) forced the judgment that motherhood is of the person.

Doctrinal fruit: Guards the unity of Christ; ground of all Marian doctrine.

Required assent: Divine and Catholic faith.

Exclusions and open questions: No origin of divinity in Mary; no divinization of her; procedural history of Ephesus remains complex and is not part of the defined object.

Synopsis — Perpetual Virginity (*Aeiparthenos*)

Object: Mary virgin in conceiving, in giving birth, and ever after: *ante partum, in partu, post partum*.

Mode and authority: Ancient dogma of universal Tradition and the ordinary universal magisterium; creeds; Constantinople II (“ever-virgin,” DS 427); exact formulation at Lateran 649, canon 3 (DS 503), papally confirmed synod.

Biblical center: Mt 1:18–25 and Lk 1:26–35 (virginal conception directly); the threefold confession received through Tradition.

Principal early witnesses: Creeds and Ignatius (virginal conception); *Protevangelium of James* as reception evidence; Jerome against Helvidius (383); *aeiparthenos* standard from the fifth century.

Thomistic support or limit: Fully affirmed (ST III, q. 28), cited at that generality.

Development hinge: Fourth-century controversy (Helvidius, Jovinian) and the conciliar fixing of *aeiparthenos*.

Doctrinal fruit: Sign of God’s absolute initiative in the Incarnation and of Mary’s undivided self-gift.

Required assent: Divine and Catholic faith.

Exclusions and open questions: No anatomical theory defined; no contempt of marriage; the “brothers” identified as kinsmen, but the cousins versus prior-marriage readings both remain undefined.

Synopsis — Immaculate Conception

Object: From the first instant of her conception Mary was preserved free from all stain of original sin, by singular grace, in view of Christ’s merits.

Mode and authority: Solemn *ex cathedra* definition: Pius IX, *Ineffabilis Deus*, 8 December 1854 (DS 2803–2804).

Biblical center: Gen 3:15 (the enmity, not the disputed pronoun) and Lk 1:28 (*kecharitomene*), read cumulatively within Tradition, not as isolated proofs.

Principal early witnesses: New Eve parallel (Justin, Irenaeus); *Panagia* praise; *immaculatam* at Lateran 649; Eastern conception feast.

Thomistic support or limit: Real limit: Thomas denied sanctification prior to animation to protect universal redemption (ST III, q. 27); the definition answers his concern through preservative redemption rather than overruling it.

Development hinge: Scotus’s preservative-redemption argument (*Ordinatio* III, d. 3, q. 1); papal steering from Sixtus IV to Alexander VII (1661) fixing the first-instant object.

Doctrinal fruit: Mary as the most perfect case of redemption; grace precedes all merit.

Required assent: Divine and Catholic faith; formal sanction on willful denial.

Exclusions and open questions: Not the virginal conception of Jesus; personal sinlessness is a distinct teaching; no pre-Nicene witness states the formula, and the medieval difficulty is honest history.

Synopsis — Assumption

Object: Mary, her earthly life completed, was assumed body and soul into heavenly glory.

Mode and authority: Solemn *ex cathedra* definition: Pius XII, *Munificentissimus Deus* §44, 1 November 1950 (DS 3903–3904), after the 1946 consultation of the episcopate.

Biblical center: No narrative text; canonical horizon: the Mother beside her Son’s lot (§38), new-Eve victory over sin and death (Gen 3:15 with 1 Cor 15, §39); Rev 12 and Ps 132 as reported figures.

Principal early witnesses: Dormition liturgy East and West; eighth-century homilists, chiefly John Damascene; early centuries genuinely silent, and the argument runs through worship and teaching.

Thomistic support or limit: Occasional affirmations only; “never dealt directly with this question” (*MD* §31); no dedicated proof claimed.

Development hinge: Scholastic fittingness arguments; post-1854 petitions; the 1946 consultation’s near-unanimity.

Doctrinal fruit: Singular participation in the Resurrection; anticipation of the Church’s own end (CCC 966, 972–974).

Required assent: Divine and Catholic faith; formal sanction on willful denial.

Exclusions and open questions: Death versus dormition deliberately left open; no place, date, or *Transitus* narrative defined; assumption is God’s act, not an ascension.

8 Notes

1. *Dei Filius*, ch. 3 (DS 3011), checked in the English presentation of the First Vatican Council’s decrees at <https://www.papalencyclicals.net/councils/ecum20.htm>, 2026-07-25. All web loci cited in these notes were read on 2026-07-25 unless another date is stated; full bibliographic detail and witness identifications are in the References. Denzinger numbers are cited as DS in the revised numbering; where a claim depends on an online Denzinger witness, the References identify it.
2. Council of Ephesus, extracts from the acts, in Henry R. Percival’s translation, NPNF series 2, vol. 14 (New York, 1900), read at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3810.htm>. The approval formally covered Cyril’s letters read in session; the second letter (DS 250–251) is the one the later tradition treats as the council’s doctrinal standard.
3. Cyril of Alexandria, second letter to Nestorius, tr. Percival, NPNF 2/14, read at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3810.htm>. Percival renders the Greek *Theotokos* as “Mother of God” throughout. The letter’s Greek text is the object approved; the English is a nineteenth-century translation witness.
4. Chalcedon, Definition of Faith, and Constantinople II, anathemas 2 and 6, tr. Percival, NPNF 2/14, read at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3811.htm> and <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3812.htm>. The Catechism’s apparatus cites the Ephesian sentence as DS 251 (CCC 495, note 145).

5. Lk 1:43 quoted from the Douay-Rheims (Challoner) translation, checked at <http://drbo.org/chapter/49001.htm>; Gal 4:4 and Jn 1:14 cited from the same version. The exegetical claim is limited to what the texts say: the one conceived and born of Mary is the Lord, God's own Son.
6. Cyril, second letter to Nestorius, tr. Percival, as above. The account of Nestorius's preaching and the council's convocation under Theodosius II follows Percival's introductions to the Ephesus documents, read at the same locus; the procedural history of Ephesus is complex, and this reference grounds the dogmatic claim in the received texts rather than in a narrative reconstruction.
7. CCC 495 with note 145, read at https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/___P1K.HTM.
8. LG 53, quoted in CCC 963, read at https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/___P2C.HTM; *Lumen gentium* checked at https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_const_19641121_lumen-gentium_en.html.
9. Constantinople II, anathemas 2 and 6, tr. Percival, NPNF 2/14, read at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3812.htm>. The Catechism's own note on the virginal motherhood cites the chain DS 291, 294, 427, 442, 503, 571, 1880 (CCC 499, note 154), placing Constantinople II (DS 427) and Lateran 649 (DS 503) inside the ordinary universal teaching.
10. DS 503 (older numbering 256), quoted from the Latin Enchiridion witness at <http://patristica.net/denzinger/enchiridion-symbolorum.html>. At "eum" that transcription prints "eam (eum?)"; the sense—that she incorruptibly bore him—is secured by the parallel English witness (Deferrari, DB 256) and by the canon's grammar, and the query mark is the transcription's, not the council's. In Deferrari's rendering the canon condemns whoever does not confess that Mary, "ever Virgin and immaculate," conceived God the Word "of the Holy Spirit without seed" and bore him with "her virginity remaining indestructible even after His birth" (*The Sources of Catholic Dogma*, read at <http://patristica.net/denzinger/>).
11. Douay-Rheims (Challoner), checked at <http://drbo.org/chapter/49001.htm>. CCC 496–498 states the Church's confession of the virginal conception and its early credal attestation.
12. CCC 500 with notes, read at https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/___P1K.HTM. The linguistic claims are stated at the level the evidence supports: these texts do not prove other children, and the Church's reading is ancient; the texts alone, without Tradition, would leave the question verbally open.
13. Jerome, *The Perpetual Virginity of Blessed Mary* (against Helvidius), identity checked at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3007.htm>; the *Protevangelium* is cited only as reception evidence. Fourth- and fifth-century usage of *aeiparthenos* (for example in Athanasius) is reported at that generality; no verbatim patristic quotation is claimed here.
14. LG 57, checked at the Vatican English text of *Lumen gentium*; CCC 499, read at https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/___P1K.HTM. Augustine's summary is quoted at CCC 510: "a virgin in conceiving her Son, a virgin in giving birth to him ... always a virgin."
15. *Ineffabilis Deus*, English text read at <https://www.papalencyclicals.net/pius09/p9ineff.htm> (translator unidentified on the witness; the same English circulates at EWTN and the New Advent library). The Vatican web page for the constitution presents only a title shell without body text in English, a checked negative result. Latin, DS 2803: "declaramus, pronuntiamus et definimus doctrinam, quae tenet, beatissimam Virginem Mariam in primo instanti suae conceptionis fuisse singulari omnipotentis Dei gratia et privilegio, intuitu meritorum Christi Jesu Salvatoris humani generis, ab omni originalis culpae labe praeservatam immunem, esse a Deo revelatam atque idcirco ab omnibus fidelibus firmiter constanterque credendam," checked at <http://patristica.net/denzinger/enchiridion-symbolorum.html>.
16. Same witness. The definition was made by Pius IX's own supreme apostolic authority after consulting the episcopate (the 1849 encyclical *Ubi primum* solicited the bishops' judgment, an act the constitution itself recounts); it is the classic instance of the *ex cathedra* mode that Vatican I would define in *Pastor aeternus* (1870), sixteen years later.
17. CCC 490–493, read at https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/___P1K.HTM; CCC 491 quotes the definition, citing DS 2803. *Lumen gentium* 56 supplies the conciliar synthesis quoted in CCC 492: she is "redeemed, in a more exalted fashion, by reason of the merits of her Son."
18. Gen 3:15 quoted from the Douay-Rheims, whose own annotation records the divergent readings, checked at <http://drbo.org/chapter/01003.htm>; the constitution's use of the verse read at the *Ineffabilis Deus* witness above.
19. Lk 1:28, Douay-Rheims, checked at <http://drbo.org/chapter/49001.htm>. The lexical claim—perfect passive participle of *charitoo*—is standard grammar; the inferential distance from greeting to dogma is stated, not concealed.
20. CCC 491–493 as above; the New Eve and *Panagia* witnesses are cited at CCC 493–494 generality. Augustine, *On Nature and Grace* 36.42, is characterized here from its accepted scope—exemption from the discussion of personal sin—and is not claimed as an Immaculate-Conception statement.

21. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 27, aa. 1–2, English (Dominican Fathers translation) read at <https://www.newadvent.org/summa/4027.htm>: “the Blessed Virgin did indeed contract original sin, but was cleansed therefrom before her birth from the womb” (a. 2). Thomas did not teach the 1854 formula; the definition answers his stated concern rather than overruling it.
22. The Scotist locus is cited by its standard reference; no critical-edition collation is claimed. The definition’s own clause *intuitu meritorum Christi Jesu* enacts the Scotist resolution without naming him.
23. Each act is recounted, with the Alexander VII sentence quoted, in *Ineffabilis Deus* itself, read at the witness above; the constitution’s notes cite Trent Sess. V and the earlier constitutions. These historical claims are made on the constitution’s own authority as a witness to its cited acts.
24. *Munificentissimus Deus* §44, English read at https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/en/apost_constitutions/documents/hf_p-xii_apc_19501101_munificentissimus-deus.html; Latin (AAS 42 [1950] 753–771) at the parallel Vatican Latin page: “pronuntiamus, declaramus et definimus divinitus revelatum dogma esse: Immaculatam Deiparam semper Virginem Mariam, expleto terrestri vitae cursu, fuisse corpore et anima ad caelestem gloriam assumptam.” Paragraph numbers follow the Vatican English presentation (48 paragraphs).
25. Same witness, §45.
26. Same witness, §§11–12, 41.
27. Same witness, §§17–21, 44. The open character of the death question is stated from the definition’s own wording; the constitution’s survey nowhere invokes the apocryphal *Transitus* literature as evidence (a checked negative within the English text), arguing instead from liturgy, Fathers, and theologians.
28. Same witness, §§26–27, 38–39. Revelation 12’s woman retains her Israel–Church–Mary polyvalence; the constitution reports the scholastics reading the Assumption as “signified” there, a typological claim.
29. Same witness, §§17–33; the Damascene sentence is quoted as the constitution quotes it (§21). Early centuries are genuinely silent about Mary’s end; the constitution’s argument is from the Church’s faith expressed in liturgy and teaching, and this reference reports that structure rather than manufacturing early eyewitnesses.
30. CCC 966, 972–974, read at https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/_P2C.HTM; LG 59 checked at the Vatican English text: “the Immaculate Virgin, preserved free from all guilt of original sin, on the completion of her earthly sojourn, was taken up body and soul into heavenly glory, and exalted by the Lord as Queen of the universe.” The Queenship named there is authoritative teaching consequent on the Assumption, not a further dogma.
31. CCC 493, 963–975, read at the Vatican IntraText pages cited above; LG 59 at the Vatican English text of *Lumen gentium*.
32. LG 60–62, checked at the Vatican English text; CCC 968–970 quotes the same passages.
33. *Mater Populi Fidelis*, §§22, 27, 67, 69, read at https://www.vatican.va/roman_curia/congregations/cfaith/documents/rc_ddd_doc_20251104_mater-populi-fidelis_en.html. Historical papal uses of “Co-redemptrix” (reviewed at §18) retain their own dates and authority; the note governs present constructive use. The note is a papally approved doctrinal note, not a solemn definition; it is the current controlling statement on these titles.

A Scope, Status, and Qualifications

Question and thesis boundary

This reference answers one question: what exactly the Catholic Church has defined in the four commonly identified Marian dogmas—divine motherhood, perpetual virginity, Immaculate Conception, and bodily Assumption—with each definition’s text, authority, history, biblical and patristic roots, exclusions, and current catechetical framing, and with the boundary between these dogmas and other Marian teaching kept explicit. It is a source-audited Catholic study instrument: not a critical edition, a magisterial act, a devotional manual, or an apparition study, and it proposes no new definition.

Corpus and exclusions

Included: the four dogmas; the defining or formulating acts (Ephesus 431 with Cyril’s second letter; Chalcedon 451 and Constantinople II 553 in reception; Lateran 649 canon 3; *Ineffabilis Deus* 1854; *Munificentissimus Deus* 1950); the catechetical loci CCC 484–511 and 963–975 and *Lumen gentium* ch. 8; and the current DDF judgment on cooperation

titles (*Mater Populi Fidelis*, 2025). Excluded: Marian feasts, prayers, devotions, iconography, and apparitions as such; Eastern and Protestant Mariologies except where a dogma’s history requires mention; critical-text questions in the conciliar acts; every question the Church has left open, which is reported as open rather than settled.

Chronological range and currentness

Subject range: from the New Testament to the DDF note of 4 November 2025. Online verification date: sources were checked 2026-07-25; stable ancient doctrine is not given artificial currentness, and the one mutable judgment used (on Marian titles) was checked in the official 2025 English text through that date.

Taxonomy and terminology

The reference distinguishes throughout: *dogma* (revealed truth proposed as such, owed divine and Catholic faith); *authoritative doctrine* (for example Mary’s personal sinlessness, Queenship, Mother of the Church); *conciliar synthesis* (*Lumen gentium*’s ordering of cooperation language); *administrative doctrinal judgment* (the 2025 note’s rule on titles); *theological opinion* (death versus dormition; cousins versus prior-marriage kinsmen); *typology* (Rev 12, Ps 132, new Eve as figure); and *apocryphal reception* (*Protevangelium*, *Transitus*). Transliterations (*Theotokos*, *aeiparthenos*, *kecharitomene*) stand for Greek originals not reproduced here.

Source hierarchy and method

Priority: defined texts in identified witnesses; then conciliar and papal acts; then the Catechism and *Lumen gentium* as current framing; then patristic and scholastic witnesses at their own dates; then scholarship. Definition texts are quoted exactly from the witnesses named in the Notes and References; historical claims inside the two papal constitutions are reported on the constitutions’ authority as witnesses to their cited acts, not re-verified in the primary archives. Latin is quoted where the defining wording matters; no project or AI translation is offered as source text—English renderings of defined formulas come only from the identified translation witnesses, and editorial paraphrase is visibly commentary.

Qualifications and unresolved items

(1) The English of *Ineffabilis Deus* used here has no identified translator; its wording is the common web text, quoted with that caution. (2) The online Latin Denzinger witness does not identify its print edition; its readings were corroborated against parallel witnesses where quoted, and its query mark at DS 503 is disclosed. (3) Percival’s 1900 translations are dated though public domain; no collation against modern critical editions (Schwartz, Riedinger, Tanner) was performed. (4) Patristic generalizations (New Eve, *Panagia*, *aeiparthenos* usage) are stated at the generality the cited catechetical sources carry and no further. (5) Scotus’s *Ordinatio* III, d. 3, q. 1 is cited by standard reference without critical-edition collation, and *potuit*, *deceit*, *fecit* is not attributed to him verbatim. (6) DS numbers follow the revised numbering as used by the Catechism’s apparatus; where only the older numbering could be checked online, both are recorded in the research records. (7) No independent Mariological, patristic, conciliar-historical, or ecclesiastical review has occurred, and no ecclesiastical approval is claimed or implied.

Rights

Project prose is original and intended for CC BY 4.0. Quotations remain under their own status: Percival (1900), Douay-Rheims, and the underlying Latin acts are public domain; Vatican web texts (CCC, *Lumen gentium*, *Munificentissimus Deus*, *Mater Populi Fidelis*) and the unattributed *Ineffabilis Deus* English are quoted within ordinary scholarly limits with citation; Deferrari’s Denzinger is used in short attributed clauses only. Online availability is not treated as a reuse license.

B References

Witnesses are listed with role and rights notes; access date for all web loci is 2026-07-25 unless stated. Stable source identities for the starred entries are registered in the repository source library; this publication's bindings are in `research/source-bindings.toml`.

Defining and formulating acts

- *Council of Ephesus (431), extracts from the acts with Cyril's second letter to Nestorius, and Chalcedon (451) and Constantinople II (553) documents, in *The Seven Ecumenical Councils*, tr. Henry R. Percival, NPNF series 2, vol. 14 (New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1900; public domain), New Advent transcriptions: <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3810.htm>, <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3811.htm>, <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3812.htm>. Role: definition-text and reception witness (divine motherhood; *aeiparthenos*).
- *Lateran Council of 649, canon 3, Latin with dual numbering (DS 503 / DB 256) at <http://patristica.net/denzipger/enchiridion-symbolorum.html>; English clauses from Roy J. Deferrari, *The Sources of Catholic Dogma* (St. Louis: Herder, 1957; rights unresolved, quoted in short attributed clauses), <http://patristica.net/denzinger/>. Role: formulation witness (perpetual virginity). The underlying seventh-century Latin is public domain; the online Latin witness does not identify its print edition and its query mark at DS 503 is disclosed in the Notes.
- *Pius IX, *Ineffabilis Deus* (8 December 1854; DS 2803–2804), English (translator unidentified on the witness) at <https://www.papalencyclicals.net/pius09/p9ineff.htm>. Role: definition text and the constitution's own historical survey (Trent Sess. V, Sixtus IV, Alexander VII 1661, the 1849 consultation). Checked negative: the Vatican web English page (<https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-ix/en/documents/18541208-costituzioni-apostolica-ineffabilis-deus.html>) delivers a title shell without body text; the Latin original is public domain.
- *Pius XII, *Munificentissimus Deus* (1 November 1950; AAS 42 [1950] 753–771; DS 3903–3904), Vatican English (48 numbered paragraphs) and Latin web texts: https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/en/apost_constitutions/documents/hf_p-xii_apc_19501101_munificentissimus-deus.html and the parallel /la/ page. Role: definition text (§44), sanction (§45), consultation record (§§11–12), and historical survey (§§17–41).

Current teaching and framing

- **Catechism of the Catholic Church*, English, Holy See web (IntraText) pages for §§484–511 and 963–975: https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/___P1K.HTM, https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/___P2C.HTM. Role: current catechetical framing; its apparatus supplied the checked DS loci (251, 427 chain, 503, 2803, 3903).
- *Second Vatican Council, *Lumen gentium* (21 November 1964), ch. 8 (§§52–69), Vatican English web text: https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_const_19641121_lumen-gentium_en.html. Role: conciliar synthesis and cooperation-language control (LG 53, 57, 59–62, 66).
- *Dicastery for the Doctrine of the Faith, *Mater Populi Fidelis* (approved 7 October 2025; published 4 November 2025), Vatican English web text: https://www.vatican.va/roman_curia/congregations/cfaith/documents/rc_dff_doc_20251104_mater-populi-fidelis_en.html. Role: current controlling judgment on Co-redemptrix (§22), mediation language (§27), and Mediatrix of All Graces (§§67–69).
- First Vatican Council, *Dei Filius* (1870), ch. 3 (DS 3011), English presentation at <https://www.papalencyclicals.net/councils/ecum20.htm> (translation identity not stated on the witness; paraphrased, not quoted). Role: criterion of dogma.

Scripture, patristic, and scholastic witnesses

- Douay-Rheims Bible (Challoner revision; public domain), drbo.org: <http://drbo.org/chapter/49001.htm> (Lk 1), <http://drbo.org/chapter/01003.htm> (Gen 3, with its annotation on *ipsa conteret*). Role: English Scripture quotations.

- Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 27 (Dominican Fathers translation, 1920; public domain), New Advent: <https://www.newadvent.org/summa/4027.htm>. Role: the Thomistic limit on the Immaculate Conception, quoted exactly; ST III, qq. 28 and 35 cited at generality only.
- Jerome, *The Perpetual Virginity of Blessed Mary* (against Helvidius, 383), NPNF 2/6 translation at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3007.htm>. Role: identity witness for the fourth-century controversy; not quoted.
- John Duns Scotus, *Ordinatio* III, d. 3, q. 1: standard scholarly reference for preservative redemption; no online witness checked, and no quotation made.

C Generation Metadata

Last revised (UTC): 2026-07-25T04:58:00Z

Model: claude-fable-5; **unexposed:** reasoning-effort and sampling configuration

Agent/runtime: Anthropic Claude Code agent (research, drafting, typesetting, review); Claude Code CLI 2.1.219; **unexposed:** server revision

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